Thomas Malthus



Malthus was born in Surrey, UK, in 1766, the seventh child of a prosperous family. After studying languages and mathematics at the University of Cambridge, he took a post as curate of a rural church. In 1798, he published an essay arguing that the rate of increase in human populations outstrips much steadier rises in food production, leading to inevitable starvation. Malthus went on to publish six further editions of the essay, and he made a number of visits to Europe to gather population data. In 1805, he was appointed Professor of History and Political Economy at the East India Company College in Hertfordshire. He became increasingly involved in debate about economic policy, and criticized the Poor Laws for causing inflation and failing to improve life for the poor. Malthus died in 1834.

Key works

1798 *An Essay on the Principle of Population*

1820 *Principles of Political Economy*

1827 *Definitions in Political Economy*

See also: Distribution of species over space and time • Metapopulations • Metacommunities • Overpopulation

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